

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1994-12-15

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í friend,

your letter of 20 September 1994 to . . . , concerning the degrees of

2 authority possessed by bahá'í historical sources, the process by which trans-

3 lations are authorized, the development of a "canon of bahá'í doctrine,"

the status of documents prepared by the research department, and your

4 request for various materials, was forwarded to the universal house of jus-

5 tice for its consideration. we are instructed to make the following reply

6 to your questions numbered two, three and five. The remaining questions

7 were referred to the research department for study. The enclosed memo-

8 randum and attachments represent the result of the deliberations of that

department.191.2

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193 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

194 1 your questions concerning translation revolve around two major issues:

195 the process by which new translations into the english language are autho-

196 rized and the authority of the translations of Shoghi effendi. we are asked

197 to state that a translation is regarded as authorized when it is approved by

198 one or more translation committees appointed by the universal house of

199 justice. while members of the research department may well, from time to

200 time, be appointed to serve on such a translation committee, the authoriza-tion of
new translations is currently not one of the responsibilities assigned to the research
department by the house of justice. further, the approval

of a translation does not mean that improvements or amendments cannot

201 be made to it in the future. As you, yourself, note, even Shoghi effendi
described his translation of the kitáb-i-íqán as
202 . . . one more attempt to introduce to the west, in a language however
inadequate, this book of unsurpassed pre-eminence among the writ-
ings of the Author of the bahá'í revelation. The hope is that it may
203 assist others in their efforts to approach what must always be regarded
204 as the unattainable goal—a befitting rendering of bahá'u'lláh's match-
205 less utterance.

206 192-1

207 As to the policy concerning the publication of new translations of the
208 writings made by individual bahá'ís, we are instructed to convey the fact
209 that translations into english and revisions of earlier translations in that lan-
210 guage must be checked by a translation committee at the bahá'í world cen-
211 ter and officially approved for publication. while individuals are permitted
212 to paraphrase or describe the contents of the passages they have translated and to
include them in their manuscripts, without reference to the world
213 center, new translations need to be submitted to the universal house of
214 justice for checking and approval prior to publication. The importance of
215 this policy lies in the fact that translations into most other languages are based on the
approved english texts and are not made directly or solely from
216 the original texts. There have been, however, occasions when the house of
217 justice has permitted the publication of provisional translations made by
218 individuals whose work is known to it. in these cases the translations usually
219 192-1. kA, p. i.192.2

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193 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

194 15appear in scholarly or other publications of limited distribution and are not
195 likely to be used as a basis for translations into other languages.

you ask whether the translations of Shoghi effendi should be consid-

196 ered as the “standard” and whether, because of his function as infallible interpreter,
the guardian’s translations provide “the true interpretation of
197 the writings.” we are asked to call attention to the introduction to The
198 qualities of the guardian’s translations and the fact that they “are illumined
199 by his uniquely inspired understanding of the purport and implications of the
originals.”

200 192-2

201 in view of your observations that “the chain of interpretation is unbroke-
202 ken, from the báb to bahá’u’lláh to ‘Abdu’l-b ahá to Shoghi effendi,” and
203 that “the ‘authorized’ interpretation of the writings ends with the guard-
204 ian,” you ask about the possibility of establishing a “canon of bahá’í doc-
205 trine which could then be regarded as ‘authorized’ and ‘official,’” and which would
serve as a means by which “truth could be separated from falsehood
206 according to the divinely revealed and interpreted standard.” in this regard,
207 the house of justice asks us to state that, while it would be possible to
208 codify and cross-reference the bahá’í teachings, it would also be impor-
209 tant to take into account such functions assigned to the universal house
210 of justice in the bahá’í writings as its role in elucidating all matters “which
211 have not outwardly been revealed in the book” and in ensuring the essential
212 flexibility of the cause.

213 192-3

214 tive function, and as such differ from interpretation. The divinely inspired legislation
of the house of justice does not attempt to say what the revealed
215 word means—it states what must be done in cases where the revealed Text
216 or its authoritative interpretation is not explicit. it is, therefore, on quite a
217 empowered to abrogate or amend its own legislation whenever it judges the
218 conditions make this desirable.

As to your question concerning whether the translations, compilations

219 and other works prepared by the research department at the bahá’í world
220 center should be considered as partaking in the infallibility of the universal

221 192-2. kA, p. 10.

222 192-3. Tb, p. 68.192.4

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193 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

194 16house of justice and, therefore, constituting the “final word,” the house

195 of justice indicates that such materials, though prepared at its direction,

196 represent the views of that department. while such views are very useful

197 as an aid to resolving perplexities or gaining an enhanced understanding of

198 the bahá’í teachings, they should never be taken to be in the same category

199 as the elucidations and clarifications provided by the universal house of

200 justice in the exercise of its assigned functions. h owever, the h ouse of j us-

201 tice chooses to convey the materials prepared by the research department

202 to the friends because it wishes them to be thoughtfully attended to and seriously
considered.

we are asked to assure you of the prayers of the universal house of

203 justice that your services to the cause will be confirmed.

204 with loving b ahá’í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

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Progress of Mount Carmel Projects

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]